DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

3.3 Impressions of Mali

Travelers have long recorded their observations as they explore new places. Travel journals from the past reveal details about places as they were long ago and also give us insight into how people reacted to different cultures.

This painting is an illustration from an Arabic manuscript from the 1200s and shows a wealthy pilgrim on his hajj, or pilgrimage to Mecca in present-day Saudi Arabia. Moroccan traveler Ibn Battuta (IBH-uhn bah-TOO-tuh) began his travels by going on his hajj in 1325. This was one year after Mansa Musa made his hajj. Stopping in Cairo, Ibn Battuta heard about Mansa Musa. The two never met, but later Ibn Battuta visited Mali. There he met Mansa Musa's brother Mansa Suleyman and began recording his observations.

CRITICAL VIEWING What mood does the painting convey?



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DOCUMENT ONE

Primary Source: Atlas
from the *Catalan Atlas, c. 1375*

Drawn by a European mapmaker, this detail from a medieval map shows West Africa and Mansa Musa, the man wearing a gold crown and holding a ball of gold. The map was made after Mansa Musa's pilgrimage to Mecca, which literally put West Africa on the map.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE What does this image suggest about the impression Mansa Musa made on people outside of Mali?



DOCUMENT TWO

Primary Source: Travel Memoir
from *Travels in Asia and Africa 1325–1354*, by Ibn Battuta

Ibn Battuta traveled throughout Africa, Europe, and Asia and wrote about his experiences. His writings help us understand the history and cultures of the places he visited. In this excerpt from his writing, he describes the entrance of the sultan, or ruler, of Mali, Mansa Suleyman.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE What impression do you think the sultan made on his audience?

> On certain days the sultan holds audiences in the palace yard, where there is a platform under a tree, with three steps. . . . The sultan comes out of a door in a corner of the palace, carrying a bow in his hand and a quiver on his back. . . . His usual dress is a velvety red tunic, made of the European fabrics called "mutanfas." The sultan is preceded by his musicians, who carry gold and silver guimbris [two-stringed guitars], and behind him come three hundred armed slaves. He walks in a leisurely fashion. . . . As he takes his seat the drums, trumpets, and bugles are sounded.

DOCUMENT THREE

Primary Source: Travel Memoir
from *Travels in Asia and Africa 1325–1354*, by Ibn Battuta

As a Muslim, Ibn Battuta was interested to see how people in other regions practiced his religion. In this excerpt, he notes what he witnessed about the observance of Islam in Mali. He admired the commitment of the people there to the religion.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE What does this description tell you about the importance of Islam in Mali?

> On Fridays, if a man does not go early to the mosque, he cannot find a corner to pray in, on account of the crowd. It is a custom of theirs to send each man his boy [to the mosque] with his prayer-mat; the boy spreads it out for his master in a place befitting him [and remains on it] until he comes to the mosque. . . . Yet another is their zeal for learning the Koran [Qur'an] by heart. They put their children in chains if they show any backwardness in memorizing it, and they are not set free until they have it by heart.

SYNTHESIZE & WRITE

1. **REVIEW** Review what you have learned about travel, trade, and religion in West Africa.
2. **RECALL** Think about your responses to the constructed response questions above. What details in the documents caused you to form these impressions?
3. **CONSTRUCT** Write a topic sentence that answers this question: What impressions did Mali make on those who traveled there?
4. **WRITE** Using evidence from this chapter and the documents, write a paragraph that supports your topic sentence.

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